

“Actually quite scrumptious once you get used to the acidity,” insisted Barbara, the brighter half of two ex-tour guides.

“This tastes like a baboon’s asshole, actually,” commented Gloria; the gloomier half of two ex-tour guides, “and I don’t care how many times you eat a baboon’s asshole, it still tastes like asshole.”

Barbara shifted her weight on the canopy tree branch she found herself atop.

“I mean sure, they’re a little acquired. They’re sour, sour like—”

“Sewage?”

“—like apple sauce that maybe has sat in the pantry for just a little too long. But it’s still perfectly edible.”

“You’re certain of that?”

“You know as well as I do we both used the same guidebook as divine gospel to get by in FAZ (Future Age Zoology) 1010: Dr. Dinkle’s Dossier on Dreadful Wildlife!

“If Dr. Dinkle says the Puckered Mushberry is safe, then the Puckered Mushberry must be safe. He tried everything in that book out himself, you know. Or sometimes an intern would try something in his place.

“Usually, if an intern had to try it, it wasn’t so safe. But the intern who ate Puckered Mushberry lived! So it must be safe!”

Gloria stretched as much as she could on the leafy bed suspended in the air she called home.

“Whatever. All I’m saying is out here in the Post-Samaritan Outback, we’ve got better food we could be choosing from. We could hunt a Goggle Goose and turn its eyes into oddly-tangy grilled skewers, or dive into the mangroves for some Decadent Mudwurst, decadent only in their weirdly appealing brackishness.

“The Great Samaritans with their ‘Argument Enders of Ultimate Peace’, for all the bad they inflicted onto this world, sure did indirectly cause a lot of brand new flora and fauna to pop into existence. And you know what that means? New FOOD. New CUISINE!”

“Like Puckered Mushberries!” Barbara chimed, offering her lounging friend some of the pale berries she kept piled up in her hand.

“No! Not like Puckered Mushberries! They’re pasty, and pale! Somehow perennially unripe and yet tasting of rot! They’re soft but tough, skin like rubber; they melt in your mouth but cake the walls and never leave!

“They taste like socks with an aftertaste of acrid anal odor! I do not like Puckered Mushberries, Barb, I do not! And no matter how many times we have to eat them for dinner, I never grow more accustomed to them! If anything, they only, get, WORSE!”

“We have the whole wild world to ourselves! We *could* be living like queens of nature! Not eating your pus-adjacent slop berries like a horse fly from the old world ate horse feces!”

Barbara pulled her berry-containing hand back toward her chest. “Well, um, fine... more for me... um...”

Gloria shook her head in disdain, mostly to herself.

“Look, you know I’m not mad at you, I’m mad at the situation. Mad at this hunt-or-be-hunted world we’ve stumbled into. I just think we could be doing a little more with our situation than hiding in trees and foraging for food so bad that even the Bundy Bunnies won’t eat it.

“But, one step at a time, you know? One night at a time. Thank you for picking these. We’ll survive, and we’ll figure out what to do tomorrow. Come on, let’s play your favorite game: inundating me with inane trivia from Dr. Dinkle’s Dossier. Come on, I’ll ask first: how did Bundy Bunnies get their name?”

Barbara sniffed, and answered despite herself. “B...Because they... *sniff*... bear an uncanny resemblance to infamous serial killer, Ted Bundy... and when Dr. Dinkle and his team met one for the first time, one of the interns was shredded into dozens of scraps of flesh in a matter of seconds...”

“Stringy scraps, or thick chunks?” Gloria asked rhetorically.

“Stringy scraps,” Barbara confirmed.

“That’s right,” Gloria smiled ruefully. “Come on, I didn’t mean all that stuff I said before, y’know. I think we’re quite alright out here. Do you think you could... give me one of those way-past-cool berries?”

Barbara complied with a bashful smile.

Gloria popped a few into her mouth and chewed, smiling at Barbara. It really, really did taste like pasty anal glue.